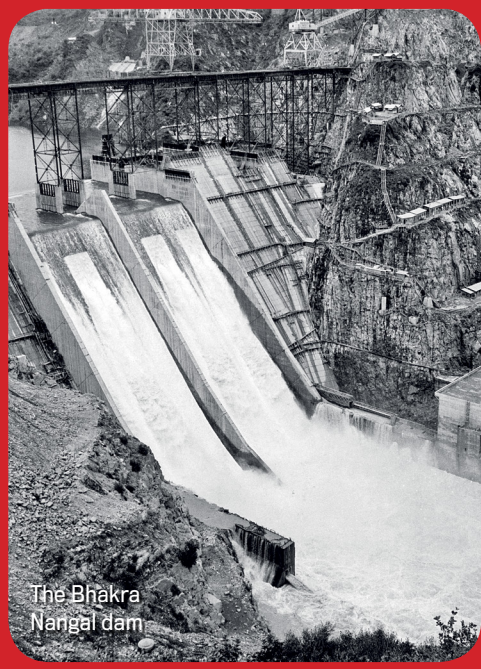
Bhakra Nangal/ Damodar Valley Corporation

Completed in 1963/came into existence in 1948

The Bhakra Nangal project, on the Sutlej River in Himachal Pradesh, is one of the oldest development projects for river valleys established after Independence. Its construction, which started in 1953, was completed in 1963 at a cost of around Rs 245.28 crore. Jawaharlal Nehru, the then prime minister, dedicated the dam to the nation, calling such projects executed by the public sector "the temples of modern India". The dam provides water for irrigation in Himachal



The Bhakra Nangal dam

GETTY IMAGES



By **VINAYAK CHATTERJEE**

Founder & Managing Trustee, The Infravision Foundation

Big, Bold and Powerful

Ten mega public infrastructure projects that have had a profound impact on post-Independence India's overall development

Indira Gandhi Canal (formerly Rajasthan Canal)

Conceived in 1948

The 650 km Indira Gandhi Canal is the longest canal in India. It starts at Harike Barrage in Punjab and ends at the irrigation facilities in the Thar Desert in western Rajasthan. Conceived in 1948 with an aim to green the semi-arid and arid areas of Rajasthan, the canal irrigates 29 lakh acres annually. The project's construction commenced in 1952 and the last portion was completed in 2010. The main 445-km-long Rajasthan canal starts after a feeder canal stretching 167 km through Punjab and Haryana and another 37 km in Rajasthan. Its route and command area cover seven districts of Rajasthan: Sriganganagar, Churu, Hanumangarh, Bikaner, Jodhpur, Jaisalmer and Barmer. The project demonstrated the widespread benefits of a massive irrigation project.



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR